

ON TECHNIQUE

Tintinnabuli

Since the mid-1970s, Pärt has used a compositional technique of his own invention, which he calls “tintinnabuli.” The method involves setting a simple, slow-moving melody with an equally simple accompaniment drawing on the most basic three-note chord, or triad. In the short piano solo *Für Alina* (1976), for example, the melody is a rising and falling major scale, accompanied by notes of the triad of that scale. The combination of notes at any moment creates a single sound that Pärt says is “simultaneously static and in flux.” Like the sound of a bell (tintinnabulation), the sounds are allowed to ring on, letting their sonorities gradually unfold.

When Arvo Pärt was born in 1935, Estonia was an independent nation state, but in 1940 it was occupied by the Soviet Red Army, and remained a part of the Soviet Union until it regained independence in 1991. Pärt was born in Paide, capital of the central Järva County; at three years old he moved with his mother to the northern town of Rakvere, where he had his first music lessons around 1942.

He showed talent, especially as a composer, and as a teenager wrote pieces in a Neo-Classical style heavily influenced by Shostakovich and Prokofiev. He had little access to anything but Soviet-approved music on which to model himself, but managed to get hold of some illicit scores and recordings, from which he learned about modern techniques such as 12-tone serialism.